

Summary

Research

After compiling everyone's research, our team found several common themes regarding current collaboration and project management tools. Many existing platforms such as Slack, Jira, Notion, Asana, GitHub Projects, and When2Meet each solve part of the workflow problem, but none provide a lightweight all-in-one solution specifically focused on quick asynchronous team status tracking for student software teams.

One of the biggest issues identified across the research was that updates and blockers often become buried inside chat applications like Slack, making it difficult for team members or leads to maintain visibility into project progress. Other tools like Jira and Asana provide strong task and sprint management features, but many team members felt that these systems can become overly complicated or require too much maintenance for smaller student teams. Scheduling and meeting coordination were also recurring frustrations, especially for students with busy or inconsistent schedules.

Across the team's research, several possible core features consistently appeared, including daily check-ins, team dashboards, reminders/notifications, blocker tracking, task statuses, scheduling support, Github integration.

Personas

From all the persona documents created, we found that many of the personas varied in role, experience level, schedules, and communication preferences. Despite these differences, most personas shared common frustrations involving poor visibility into team progress, scattered communication, difficulty tracking blockers, and too many unnecessary meetings. Many personas also emphasized the need for lightweight asynchronous collaboration.

- Mena Malik: A busy CS senior balancing classes and internships who wanted a quick way to log progress and signal blockers without long meetings.
- Little Sam: An introverted developer who preferred asynchronous communication to reduce the pressure of constant real-time discussions.
- Cheryl: A team supervisor who wanted better visibility into team schedules, progress, and blockers to prevent delays.

- Kevin: A backend developer with an inconsistent schedule who wanted a centralized way to track daily updates and team activity.
- Olivia: A frontend developer who wanted a simple way to stay updated on team progress, schedules, and current tasks while maintaining flexible communication.

User stories

Many of the user stories varied between team members, but generally followed the common trend of describing a specific type of software team member, identifying a collaboration problem they face, and explaining what feature they would want in an ideal team status tracking system. Common themes included improving team visibility, simplifying communication, reducing unnecessary meetings, and making blocker tracking easier.

- A busy CS student wanted quick daily reminders and short check-ins so teammates could stay updated without meetings.
- A frontend developer wanted to quickly submit updates and view team status to stay aligned with the team's progress.
- An introverted developer wanted an asynchronous platform to share updates and blockers without relying on public communication.
- A backend developer wanted to monitor team activity and blockers in one place to avoid constant meetings.
- A team lead wanted visibility into daily progress and blockers so sprint risks could be identified early.
- A software engineer with limited time availability wanted an easier way to constantly keep track of tasks and sprint deadlines without wasting time navigating through complicated project structures.

Concrete feature ideas based on user research

- Functionality to keep track of each team members' progress and blockers
- Simplicity (interpreted as a simple UI and lack of complex features)
- Alleviate the need for synchronous activity/meetings— This might suggest a place to leave detailed notes for others to read asynchronously